

Don De Castro

Technical Animator | Motion Edit Supervisor | Virtual Production

Los Angeles, CA • dondecastro@gmail.com • dondecastro.com • LinkedIn • YouTube • B.S. Media Arts, Art Institute of California, 2003

Technical Animator and Motion Edit Supervisor with 20+ years across feature film, AAA games, theme park attractions, and virtual production. Core expertise in motion capture supervision, retargeting pipeline design, character simulation, and production tool development. Currently building Unreal Engine 5 plugins and editor tools using Claude Code and LLM-native development workflows.

Experience

Technical Director / Developer | Independent Short Animation Project

2025 to Present

- Developing custom Unreal Engine 5 plugins with Claude Code; LLM-native agentic coding for editor tools and pipeline automation, integrated into active animation production.

Motion Edit Supervisor | Lightstorm Entertainment, Avatar: The Way of Water & Fire and Ash

2017 to 2025

- Directed on-set motion capture operations across two feature films over 8+ years of continuous shooting and post-production; primary technical liaison on set.
- Designed a flexible retargeting pipeline for significant actor-to-CG-character scale differences, including a dynamic workflow for a growing child actor (Spider/Jack Champion).
- Defined the technical approach for underwater performance capture, working with developers to solve novel data challenges (splashes, bubbles, refractions, surface-crossing) with no existing industry solutions.
- Built ingestion and delivery pipelines for internal teams and external vendors; oversaw scene-wide motion stitching for continuous performances during virtual cinematography.

WDI Visual Ride Designer | Lightstorm Entertainment, Pandora: The World of Avatar (Walt Disney World)

2016 to 2017

- Partnered with the Production Designer and Ride Design Supervisor on Flight of Passage; animated creatures for projection mapping onto physical props, blending digital and practical elements.

Motion Capture Consultant | Sony PlayStation, Spider-Man & God of War

2014 to 2016

- Trained Sony's MoCap crew and stage personnel on advanced motion capture software and workflows; freelance pipeline training across external studio projects.

Motion Edit Supervisor | Giant Studios (Avatar, Call of Duty: Advanced Warfare, Shadow of Mordor, World of Warcraft, others)

2003 to 2014

- Led the editor team generating all Na'vi character motions for the original Avatar, the highest-grossing film of its era.
- Defined the technical ingest and delivery pipeline used to transfer motion data to Lightstorm's Virtual Lab; workflows remained in use years later.
- Designed and implemented the Virtual Production and Simulcam workflow streamlining on-set operations across multiple AAA game and film projects; built automation tools (Shell, MEL).
- Managed complex rig assimilation: adapting external rig formats to proprietary software and delivering refined motion back to source format.

Character FX (concurrent parallel track) | Sony Imageworks, Blue Sky, Blur Studios, Rhythm and Hues

2004 to 2016

- Hair, cloth, and creature simulation across feature film and game cinematics in Maya, Qualoth, Marvelous Designer, Katana, and Rhythm and Hues' in-house Voodoo system.

Technical Skills

Pipeline & Automation: Python, Shell scripting, MEL, custom tool development, data pipeline design.

AI & LLM Tools: Claude Code, LLM-native plugin development, agentic coding workflows.

DCC & Real-Time: Maya, MotionBuilder, 3ds Max, Katana, Unreal Engine 5 (C++, Blueprints, Editor Plugins).

Specializations: Motion Capture (on-set and post), Virtual Production, Simulcam, Performance Capture, Rigging, Retargeting, Cloth/Hair/Creature Simulation.

Selected Credits

Motion Edit / Capture: Avatar: Fire and Ash, Avatar: The Way of Water, Avatar, Pandora (Disney), Call of Duty: Advanced Warfare, Shadow of Mordor, Real Steel, The Polar Express.

Character FX: Ice Age 5, Hotel Transylvania 2, Star Wars Jedi: Fallen Order, Halo 2 Anniversary, Alice in Wonderland, Open Season.